4D Competency Quick-Reference Card

AI Literacy for the Modern Workforce

The 4Ds describe four competencies for effective, responsible AI use at work. They operate in two loops. The Delegation–Diligence loop governs the strategic decisions: whether and when to use AI. The Description–Discernment loop governs the operational workflow: how to work with AI effectively.



"Should I use AI for this?"



"How do I work with AI effectively?"

DELEGATION

Deciding what work is appropriate for you, for AI, or for both.

Problem Awareness

WHAT IT MEANS

Understanding your goals and the nature of the work before involving AI.

WHAT YOU DO

Define the task goal. Identify which components require human judgment and which are appropriate for AI assistance.

Platform Awareness

WHAT IT MEANS

Understanding the capabilities and limitations of the AI tool you are using.

WHAT YOU DO

Identify what the tool generates reliably vs. where it systematically fails, before delegating. Check that the tool fits your organization's operational and regulatory rules for the task.

Task Delegation

WHAT IT MEANS

Distributing work between humans and AI to draw on the strengths of each.

WHAT YOU DO

Distinguish augmentation from automation. Decompose tasks by stakes, verifiability, and your domain expertise.

DESCRIPTION

Communicating what you need from AI clearly enough to get a useful result.

Product Description

WHAT IT MEANS

Defining what you want the output to look like.

WHAT YOU DO

Specify format, audience, length, detail level, and quality criteria before generating.

Process Description

WHAT IT MEANS

Guiding how the AI should approach the task.

WHAT YOU DO

Provide methods, steps, constraints, and reasoning sequence. Break a complex task into a series of smaller prompts and work through them in dialogue. Give context, not single-turn directives.

Performance Description

WHAT IT MEANS

Shaping how the AI behaves during the interaction.

WHAT YOU DO

Set expectations for tone, voice, directness, and priorities. Iterate rather than accept/discard first results.

DISCERNMENT

Evaluating what AI gives you back before you use it.

Product Discernment

WHAT IT MEANS

Evaluating whether the output meets your specification.

WHAT YOU DO

Verify factual claims, citations, and statistics against independent sources. Identify hallucination indicators.

Process Discernment

WHAT IT MEANS

Evaluating whether the AI's reasoning is sound and whether the way you are working with it is producing results.

WHAT YOU DO

Check for logical gaps, unsupported assumptions, and circular reasoning. Trace the reasoning, not just the conclusion. When outputs keep missing, change the approach: more context, smaller steps, or a different tool.

Performance Discernment

WHAT IT MEANS

Evaluating whether the AI's behavior matched what you needed.

WHAT YOU DO

Assess whether tone, register, and style match the intended audience. Flag deviations from your instructions.

DILIGENCE

Taking responsibility for what you do with AI and how you do it.

Creation Diligence

WHAT IT MEANS

Using AI responsibly: within ethical and legal limits, aware of bias, flaws, and who is affected.

WHAT YOU DO

Check outputs for bias and ethical risk before you build on them. Stay within legal and organizational rules for the data and the use.

Transparency Diligence

WHAT IT MEANS

Being honest about AI's role in your work with everyone who needs to know.

WHAT YOU DO

Document which components were AI-generated, AI-assisted, or human-authored. Know what your audience, your industry, and the law expect about disclosure. Discuss practices openly.

Deployment Diligence

WHAT IT MEANS

Verifying and vouching for the outputs you share.

WHAT YOU DO

Take full accountability before sharing. Apply the same review standard as work from a junior colleague.

Framework: the 4D AI Fluency Framework (Dakan & Feller, 2025, ringling.libguides.com/ai/framework), as taught in Anthropic's AI Fluency: Framework & Foundations (2025). Sub-component names and most definitions follow the course, including its conversational reading of the two Performance sub-components; the source document names the first Delegation sub-component Goal and Task Awareness. Creation Diligence and Process Discernment draw on the source document's definitions. Action verbs are adapted for workplace use. The two loops pair the competencies that the crossing arrows join in the source document's competency diagram (Fig. 1, p. 3); that diagram also links each competency to its two neighbors. The loops and their strategic and operational labels are this program's.

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